further doubted that China would open two fronts on the east (i.e., north and south of India's northeast) as some feared, because of the logistical and political problems that fighting through Burma would entail.[31]

This American perception shaped its view of the correct approach for India to take in dealing with the China threat. That, in turn, shaped views of the US in India, where the threat felt more acute and imminent. Different diagnoses led to either different prescriptions or, at the very least, similar prescriptions but different ideas of the correct dose.

Parley with Pakistan

The lack of a sense of urgency in Washington partly contributed to a US prescription that India had trouble digesting. Many in the Kennedy administration believed that India could ease its threat environment vis-à-vis China by making peace with Pakistan and thus eliminating part of its overall defense problem. There were two aspects to the administration's approach to this Pakistan angle. First, Kennedy instructed Harriman to tell Pakistani leader Ayub Khan that the war had "radically" changed the situation in South Asia for the US, and to warn Pakistan against "mov[ing] closer to the Chinese at a time when we were assisting India to confront Communist China." Second, believing that the war had given Washington "a one-time opportunity to bring about a Pak-Indian reconciliation," it meant getting the two sides to the negotiating table.[32]

Despite reservations about public opinion and Pakistani reciprocity, Nehru agreed to hold talks with Pakistan without preconditions. He and Ayub released a joint communiqué facilitated by the US and UK on November 30 that stated that they would try to resolve outstanding differences on Kashmir and other issues. Subsequently, between December 1962 and May 1963, the two countries conducted six rounds of talks. By mid-April, there would be a stalemate, with Pakistan unwilling to make concessions, and Komer believing that the US could not push Nehru any further.[33] The talks would not result in a Kashmir solution, but they would have an impact on US-India cooperation vis-à-vis China.

Kennedy acknowledged how difficult it was for Nehru to move on this front with the persistent Chinese threat, but reconciliation with Pakistan would allow India to concentrate its economic and military resources to defend itself against China. Eventually, it might also make an India-